

Socialism in Europe and The Russian Revolution

Date: / /

→ The age of social change :

- The French Revolution opened up the possibility of creating a dramatic change in the way in which society was structured.
- Not everyone in Europe, however, wanted a complete transformation.
- Some were 'conservatives', while others were 'liberals' or 'radicals'.

→ Who were conservatives?

- They resisted change.
- After the Revolution, they started accepting change provided it was slow and had links and respected the past.

→ Who were liberals?

- They wanted a nation which tolerated all religions.
- They argued for an elected parliamentary government, subject to laws interpreted by a well trained judiciary that was independent of rulers and officials.
- They were not Democrats.

→ Who were Radicals?

- They wanted a nation in which government was based on the majority of a country's population.
- They disliked concentration of property in hands of a few, not the existence of private property.

→ Industrial Society and Social change:

- This was the time of economic and social change.
- Man, women and children were pushed into factories for low wages.
- Most of the factory owners were often liberals and radical and they felt that worker's effort must be encouraged.

→ The coming of socialism to Europe:

- Socialists were against private property.
- They had different visions of the future.
- Some believed in cooperatives.
- Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels added that

Industrial society was capitalist

→ Support For Socialism:

- By the 1870s, Socialist ideas spread through Europe.
- Workers in England and Germany began forming associations to fight for better living and working conditions.

→ The Russian Revolution:

- In 1914 Nicholas II ruled the Russian Empire.
- The Russian Empire included territory around Moscow, current-day Finland, Latvia, Lithuania, Estonia, parts of Poland, Ukraine and Belarus.

→ Economy and Society during Russian Empire:

- About 85 percent of the Russian Empire's population earned their living from agriculture.
- The industry was limited in numbers.
- Workers were divided into groups but they did unite to strike work when they

were dissatisfied.

- Peasants had no respect for nobility, very unlike the French peasant.
- Russian peasants were the only peasants community which pooled their land and their commune divided it.

→ Socialism in Russia :

- All political parties were illegal in Russia before 1914.
- In 1900, the Russian Socialist Democratic Labour party was formed.

→ It struggled to give peasants their rights over land that belonged to nobles

→ As land was divided among peasants periodically and it was felt that peasants and not workers would be the main source of the revolution.

- But Lenin did not agree with this as he felt that peasants were not one social group.

→ The party was divided into Bolsheviks and Mensheviks.

→ Lenin led Bolshevik group.

→ A Turbulent Time: The 1905 Revolution:

- Liberals wanted to end of the autocracy of the Tsar.
- They worked towards demanding a constitution during the Revolution 1905.

→ Bloody Sunday:

- In 1904, prices of essential goods rose so quickly that real wages declined by 20%.
- When four members of the Putilov Iron Works were dismissed, there was a call for Industrial Action.
- Over 110,000 workers in St. Petersburg went on strike demanding a reduction in working hours and increase in wages.
 - This procession was attacked by the police and Cossacks.
 - Over 100 workers killed.
 - Strike took place as a reaction.
 - People demanded a constituent assembly.
- The Tsar allowed the creation of an elected consultative parliament or Duma.
 - The Tsar dismissed the first Duma within 75 days and announced the election of a second duma.

→ Tsar constituted the Third Duma with conservative politicians.

→ The First World War and the Russian Empire (1914-1918)

- In Russia, the First World War was initially very popular but later the support grew thin.
- Anti-German sentiments ran high.
- Russian armies lost badly in Germany and Austria.
- The war also affected the industry.
- There was labour shortage.
- By 1916, railway lines began to break down.
- The small workshops were closed down.
- There were shortage of grain and hence of bread.

→ The February Revolution in Petrograd ÷

Events ÷

- In Winter of 1917, Petrograd was grim.
→ There was a food shortage in the quarters of workers.

- On 22th February, a lockout took place at a factory.
 → Workers of 50 other factories joined in sympathy.
 → Women also led and participated in the strikes. This came to be called the International Women's Day (8 March).
- The Government imposed a curfew.
- On the 24th and 25th, the government called out the cavalry and police to keep eye on them.
- On 25th February the government suspended the Duma and politician spoke against this measure.
- On 27th February, the police headquarters were ransacked.
 → Cavalry was called out again.
 → An officer was shot at the barracks of a regiment and other regiment mutinied, voting to join the striking workers gathered to form a Soviet or council. This was the Petrograd Soviet.
- A delegation went to meet the Tsar. military command advised him to abdicate.
- Soviet leaders and Duma leaders formed a provisional Government to run the country.

→ Effects ÷

- Most Industry and banks were nationalised in November 1917.
- The land was declared social property and peasants are allowed to seize the land of nobility.
- Use of old titles was banned.
- New Uniform were designed for the army and officials.
- Russia become a one party state.
- Trade unions were kept under party control.

→ The Civil War ÷

- When the Bolsheviks ordered land redistribution, the Russian army began to breakup.
- Non-Bolsheviks Socialists, liberals and supporters of autocracy condemned the Bolsheviks uprising → They were supported by French, American, British and Japanese Troops.
- All these fought a war with the Bolsheviks.

→ Making Socialist Society:

- The Bolsheviks kept Industries and banks nationalised during the civil war.
- Rapid construction and Industrialization started.
- An extended schooling system developed.

→ Stalin collective Farming:

- Stalin believed that rich peasants and traders stocked supplies to create a shortage of grains. Hence collectivisation was the need of the hour.
- Those Farmers who resisted collectivisation were punished, deported or exiled.

→ Global Influence:

- In many countries communist parties were formed.
- By the time of the outbreak of the Second World War, the USSR had given Socialism a global face and world stature.
- By the end of the twentieth century, the international reputation of the USSR as a Socialist

country had declined.

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